

PARALLEL LIVES

This searing first novel traces an escape route from Calcutta to Oxford and London, and into an imagined past



PAST CONTINUOUS

by NEEL MUKHERJEE

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■ By Brinda Bose

I came across a review of Neel Mukherjee's *Past Continuous* in a national magazine before I read the novel itself (as untimely travels on my part delayed my receiving it for review). While commenting on its parallel narrative (the story of a Miss Gilby, a Bimala and a Nikhilesh), the review failed to note its obvious, critical connection to *Ghare Baire*—Rabindranath Tagore's text and Satyajit Ray's film—signalled though it was by one of the novel's epigraphs, as I discovered subsequently. I wondered if any review of Jean Rhys' or Peter Carey's memorable re-visitations of the English literary canon could have done them justice if it had disregarded such a crucial postcolonial 'turn'.

I wondered, then, whether Mukherjee's debut novel, rooted so viscerally in Calcutta, Oxford and London, and banking upon the reader's recognition of its 're-writing' of India's colonial history (by exploring a marginal British character in Tagore's novel), was primarily for those who happened to know Calcutta, Oxford, London, Tagore and Ray viscerally too, if not necessarily as painfully as Mukherjee and or his protagonist do. After all, if you had some gleanings of Bengali culture, you would at least recall Jennifer Kendall's Miss Gilby teaching Bimala to sing *Long, long ago* in Ray's popular, if flawed, film version of *Ghare Baire*. And if you ever knew Oxford as a naïve young student fresh from India, you would certainly remember your bemusement upon being served sherry at your very first tutorial.

Ritwik Ghosh, talented and tormented, is both teller and tale in *Past Continuous*. In interleaved chapters, Mukherjee's protagonist comes of age

in the grim by-lanes of middle-class south Calcutta—abused and orphaned in quick succession. That Ritwik is prey to a mother's malevolent love in his childhood (which he could identify as abuse only long after she had died) is the icing on the bitter cake of a life lived in humiliating poverty amidst mean, inquisitive relatives and a pervasive hostility of spirit and intellect. He escapes to Oxford on a scholarship, and then grows up suddenly and viciously when he chooses to be an illegal wanderer on London's streets and in its public toilets, looking for (gay, paid) sex in all the wrong places.

Unlike the usual diaspora novel, *Past Continuous* is untouched by even

(or a condom). Miss Gilby (somewhat like E.M. Forster's Adela Quested) resurfaces in her homeland, scarred but uncharred by the fires of Indian nationalism, while Ritwik's life gutters in the grey streets of his adopted city of London. And thereby hangs the tale.

The greatest strength of Mukherjee's searing first novel is its astonishing ability to produce the literary equivalent of cinéma vérité, because he can uncannily capture a street, a smell, a snatch of song with wordplay that can sting your memories into a renaissance. But this is not to say that the novel is geo-culturally delimited; Mukherjee debuts impressively with a pen that lacerates afresh every

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a remote whiff of nostalgia. Ritwik's raging desire to escape—into a future, far away from Calcutta, and into a past historically antagonistic to the lived reality of his own—is simultaneously transcribed in the parallel narratives of the text, the one that follows Ritwik from Calcutta to Oxford and London, and the other that Ritwik creates, weaving a story for the peripheral Miss Gilby of Bimala's home and world, in and out of the chapters that trail his perilous postcolonial peregrinations. Ritwik finds an odd solace in his hazardous homosexual identity—and activity—that fits his life's tale like a glove

wounded recollection that it uncovers. Where it fails, however, is in sustaining the intensity of such a scorcher, for the first half of the novel promises more than the second can deliver. And while there is no real disconnect between the novel's parallel narratives, Mukherjee is unable (or unwilling?) to illumine the seams. There is, in fact, a discomfiting sense that Mukherjee treats his readers with the same disdain that he throws at the cities of his birth, growth and devolution. But then, one could surely do worse than be identified with some of the most fascinating, if dark-est, places on earth. ■